pointed out that as national news channels, our telecast was being beamed across India. ‘Well, then I leave it to your judgement as to how to ensure the law is not violated,’ was his parting shot.

I rang up Shazi, summarizing the gist of my conversation with the CEC. My suggestion was that, ‘Whatever decision we take should be a collective one.’ Frankly, I didn’t want to risk being isolated on the issue.

The next morning, every news channel showed the telecast live even though I think we were all aware we were flirting with the election law. Our public defence—this was a news-worthy event that had to be telecast in viewer and national interest. Our private admission—we know it violates the law, but hey, let’s take a chance, especially as the Election Commission hasn’t sent us anything specific in writing.

The same philosophy applied again when Modi was filing his nomination from Varanasi on 24 April. It was a really big polling day—117 seats were polling across twelve states. Did a live roadshow of Modi in Varanasi while polling was on in other places constitute an election law violation? It was an open question. Maybe it did or maybe the law itself was outdated in a multi-phase election where every event is in any case being played out on the Internet. The Election Commission’s Model Code of Conduct over a nine-phase election violates the Code of Common Sense, fulminated voices on Twitter.

But even if it was legal, was it morally right? Sadly, none of us wanted to even consider raising the troubling ethical questions. Modi was on an impressive march of victory; he was box office—the man the country wanted to see and listen to. We were happy to simply allow the TV studio to be a loudspeaker for his voice, and almost wilfully participate in the propaganda offensive. Cumbersome election laws be damned. Our moral compass as journalists had shifted, almost irreversibly, in the race for TRPs.

On TV, Modi was the dramatic binary contrast to Manmohan Singh and Rahul, the Bharatiya, even ‘Dabang’ action man, compared to the disconnected Luytensland dynasty. Starved of drama and communication by the uncommunicative UPA and silent Manmohan, the TV camera veered thirstily to Modi for the continuous theatrics and hard-hitting sound bites